



TARTING IN 1987, the US television series *Star Trek: The Next Generation* featured Captain Jean-Luc Picard ordering the Food Replicator for “Tea. Earl Grey. Hot!” This captured the imagination of millions as they

got a peek into a futuristic alternative reality. Sadly, the Food Replicator is still far from reality, unlike a dozen other sci-fi predictions such as self-driving cars and space travel. But there’s hope, with home-grown robot companies and cloud kitchen start-ups like Mukunda Foods, Xook and RoboChef working to make this a reality. In fact, some of them used the Replicator as an analogy when starting out to build robotic solutions for commercial kitchens.

“Food replication might be sci-fi today, but the industry is certainly moving towards special focus products, and then towards multi-purpose machines focussing on specific kinds of food. That will become a more pervasive reality in the food robotics segment. Automation is a must for companies that want cooked food delivered in 10 minutes,” says Rajagopal Natarajan, Co-founder of Bengaluru-based start-up Xook that offers meal preparation robots, co-working office spaces and apartment complexes. While customers can personalise their food based on taste preferences like spicy, sweet, creamy, or saucy, these machines can rustle up salads and six other types of dishes within two minutes!

A new phenomenon in the country, a dozen tech start-ups like Xook are operating a kitchen-as-a-service (KaaS) model in the Indian food service delivery market that is expected to double in value to \$13 billion by 2025, according to research firm RedSeer. A report by Motilal Oswal pegs the market in India to grow at over 30 per cent CAGR between 2021 and 2026. Meanwhile, the global online food delivery services market size is expected to grow from \$115.11 billion in 2021 to \$128.32 billion in 2022 at a CAGR of 11.5 per cent, according to the Business Research Company.

Bengaluru-based Mukunda Foods is another kitchen robotics firm leveraging this trend. Founded nearly two decades ago as a quick service restaurant (QSR), today it is powering food delivery platform Zomato’s 10-minute delivery dream. Earlier this year, Zomato bought a 16.66